

Marketing probiotic beverages

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20.1 Introduction

In this chapter, the goal is to provide an overview of the marketing of probiotic beverages. Areas examined include the market size, the probiotic consumer target, wants and needs of probiotic consumers, and how to use marketing to connect with probiotic consumers. Examples of new products on the market are used to illustrate the latest trends, how these products are currently being marketed, and what opportunities exist but are still in their infancy. Mainstream products such as kombucha and yogurt drinks are well-covered elsewhere in this book; therefore, the main focus in this chapter is on trending and novel probiotic beverages.

20.2 Global market size

By 2022, the overall global beverage category is expected to grow to a value of \$1 trillion USD ([Euromonitor, 2018](#)). Within global beverages, the functional beverage category is one of the fastest-growing segments, growing from \$55 billion USD in 2010 to over \$94 billion USD in 2019 ([Grand View Research, 2020](#)). This growth is a reflection of the rising consumer interest in functional beverages and the market opportunity that this is creating.

There are two key drivers growing the global probiotic beverage market: a rise in disposable personal income and an increasing geriatric population. The total global population in 2020 is 7.8 billion, of which ~780 million are geriatric. The UN estimates that by the year 2050, there will be 1.5 billion people over the age of 65, and the global life expectancy beyond 65 is projected to increase by 19 years ([UN-DESA, 2020](#)). This will

result in a shift from 1 in 11 people over the age of 65 in 2019 to 1 in 6 people over the age of 65 by 2050. This change in demographic composition creates a new market opportunity, especially for products such as probiotic beverages. When surveyed by age group, the current consumer age bracket with the highest interest in probiotic beverages are those aged 18–34 (32%) ([FoodNavigator, 2017](#)). While the current geriatric consumers are underserved in terms of marketing efforts on probiotic beverages, as today's younger high-interest group ages over the next several years, more targeted marketing and product positioning will be required to appeal to this rapidly expanding age group's needs.

While the North American probiotic market is still in the early growth stage, an already well-established market exists in Asia where consumers buy probiotics for their health benefits. Over 42% of Chinese consumers purchase beverages marketed as having digestive benefits ([Mintel, 2017](#)). The market growth opportunity in Asia is expected to come not only from products targeting the growing geriatric market but also from consumer demand for products offering health benefits to young children. Europe, the second biggest market for probiotic beverages after Asia, is expected to have consistent but moderate growth over the next few years as probiotics move out of specialty retailers into mainstream supermarkets and convenience stores. In Latin America, the expanding middle-class is driving growth in the probiotic market, with Brazil representing both the highest market share in Latin America as well as the fastest-growing market.

20.3 Consumer needs and wants

In April of 2020, the International Food Information Council Foundation carried out a food and health survey in which American consumers ranked in terms of importance what they were seeking from food and beverages. The highest consumer priorities were as follows: weight loss management (>60%), feeling better with more energy (>55%), and products that offered digestive health benefits, and these were third in importance (45%). Standing out as distinctive in their consumer benefits, probiotics were perceived as healthy (65%), as were prebiotics (~45%) ([IFIC, 2020](#)). The FMCG Gurus, a UK market research company, in April of 2020, surveyed 23,000 respondents across 18 countries providing a broader, international perspective on consumer preferences ([FMCG Gurus, 2020](#)). Consumers reported having become more conscious about their overall health (59%) and more concerned about their health immunity status due to COVID-19. As this study was conducted during the early months of the COVID-19 global pandemic, the increased interest in overall health and immunity could have been heightened by the global

health environment at the time of the survey. Globally, 57% of the consumers reported their health concern level was growing, with rising concerns in South America (61%), North America (59%), Europe (58%), Asia Pacific (55%), and Africa and the Middle East (51%). Boosting immunity to reduce vulnerability to disease is a topic that is more important to consumers in 2020 than it ever was in the previous years.

Consumers are no longer thinking just about digestive health. They are seeking both physical and mental health benefits and regard them as having equal importance. The 2018 Innova Market Insights Survey reported that eight out of ten consumers agreed that mental health was as important as physical health to them, with an even higher agreement in China and Brazil (nine out of ten respondents) ([Innova, 2018](#)). This consumer interest in mental health creates a growing market opportunity for products that address brain health in addition to physical health in both their components and in their marketing material.

Consumers are looking for more than hydration from beverages. Time-crunched and convenience-driven consumers are seeking beverages that offer additional benefits, such as energy, nutrients, health, and wellness. This desire for *hydration+benefits* is especially true for the millennial cohort. In a survey by the [Hartman Group \(2019\)](#), 65% of millennial respondents agreed to the statement “beverages play a very important role in my health and wellness.” While the *+benefits* element of beverage preferences vary by consumer, top consumer benefit preferences include the following: a source of calcium (63%), fiber (61%), reduced sugar (61%), source of antioxidants (60%), increased protein (57%), source of omega 3 (55%), and a beverage that contains probiotics (46%) ([Winsight, 2018](#)).

20.4 The market for probiotic beverages spans dayparts, occasions, and consumer preferences

Kerry research surveys in 2019 noted that the majority (68%) of the consumers surveyed said that they would prefer to consume foods with immunity-boosting benefits at breakfast. The potential for probiotic beverages to span dayparts and occasions is vast. Already, probiotic beverages are often consumed as a part of breakfast, or a mid-morning or mid-afternoon snack ([Kerry, 2020](#)). Beverages are consumed seated, on-the-go as snacks, and as meal replacements. The drinking of beverages is becoming increasingly acceptable in most spaces be that at work, in cars, on public transit, in public places, and walking. Cultural norms about drinking behavior have changed over the past years. Consumers no longer drink beverages during fixed time points during the day and instead, they have evolved into “constant sippers,” with 65% of the consumers saying that they always have a beverage on hand ([Hartman Group, 2019](#)).

When considering consumers of different ages, incomes, life stages, and geographies, there will be differences based on multiple factors, but a number of common themes still emerge. The importance of convenience cannot be overstated. When consumers are seeking convenience, a probiotic beverage can be an easy option to add to their daily routine.

Consumers want products that are safe, trustworthy, and efficacious. They want to be able to trust that the product will deliver upon the marketing promises. Probiotic drink consumers are looking not only for information on product ingredients and benefits, but they are also expecting that the information will be communicated in an accessible way and offer full transparency. They want the information to be available on the product packaging and access to information about the manufacturer as well.

Consumers are seeking products that are sustainable for the planet and offer an assurance that the company producing the product demonstrates corporate social responsibility. In 2018, 65% of global consumers said they expect companies to invest in sustainability and by 2019 this had increased to 87% of consumers (Innova, 2020). How consumers interpret corporate social responsibility is evolving over time. What was once a heavy focus on environmental impacts and sustainable business practices in 2020 has expanded in the mind of the consumers to include a focus on how corporations are protecting and supporting their employees, as well as consumers and first responders, especially in the time of COVID-19 (Mintel, 2020).

With the growing variety of options available in the global beverage market, in parallel, a consumer interest in novelty and taste exploration has developed. Often referred to as “food explorers” or “flavor explorers,” many consumers seek novelty or unique experiences in their beverage choices. The potential to customize a drink to one’s own specific needs, ranks high as a future market opportunity (Innova Market Insights Trends for 2020).

Finally, and arguably most important, great taste remains the strongest driver of consumer purchase intent and satisfaction. Offering *Hydration + Benefits* without great taste is a hard sell to any consumer, and with the wide range of available products, to be competitive in the global marketplace, ensuring that the product tastes great to the target consumer cannot be ignored. Great taste, followed by the product specialization that best addresses the consumer’s specific priorities/beliefs, has led to an abundance of new products on the market (e.g., vegan, gluten-free, dairy-free, certified organic). *Taste + Hydration + Benefits* has led to the development of hybrid beverage products, such as drinks containing a blend of dairy milk and almond milk as well as the introduction of cosmeceutical drink products promising muscle health, hair health, and skin health all in the market space of traditional probiotic drinks (Innova, 2020).

20.5 Beyond probiotics

While this book focuses largely on probiotic beverages, the range of beverages associated with some form of “biotics” is vast. Beyond probiotics, the beverage market has expanded to include products with added prebiotics, postbiotics, psychobiotics, paraprobiotics, adaptogens, and nootropics. All of these are offered in various symbiotic combinations, which are proposed to make them more effective.

Prebiotics encourage the growth of probiotic bacteria in the digestive tract. In beverages, prebiotics are typically soluble fibers (e.g., inulin) or oligosaccharides (e.g., fructooligosaccharides (FOS)). Prebiotics can aid with beverage stability, and some prebiotics add a sweetness level that allows for a reduction in the need for added sugars. Some products now feature a suite of prebiotics from “different families,” which lend themselves to “clean-label, food-based” functional benefits, making resistant starch and polyphenols (which have an antioxidant function) consumer-valued additions to traditional prebiotics.

There is no overall consensus on the term “postbiotic.” Postbiotics are most often described as metabolites of probiotics although what falls into this classification is not well defined. Postbiotics are bioactive compounds produced by food-grade microorganisms during a fermentation process and can include microbial cells, cell constituents, and metabolites (Wegh, Geerlings, Knol, Roeselers, Belzer, 2019). Interest in the role of postbiotics is expected to grow as early research shows that postbiotics appear to have a direct positive effect in healthy individuals to improve their overall health and they may increase the potency of the probiotics.

The terms “psychobiotics,” “paraprobiotics,” “adaptogens,” and “nootropics” are new additions to the terms making their way into consumer marketing language. Psychobiotics are probiotics that offer benefits to mental health. Paraprobiotics are nonviable microorganisms or metabolites able to provide physiological health benefits to consumers, or the term “parabiotic” may refer to the therapeutic action related to probiotics. Adaptogens are promoted as supporting the body in handling mental and physical stress. Adaptogens are often herbs or roots. Nootropics are compounds for improving cognitive function (brain health and performance), such as enhancing memory and facilitating learning. As an example, caffeine is a compound that has been shown to improve both mental function and physical performance.

New-to-market probiotic beverages increasingly consist of blends of probiotics with psychobiotics, paraprobiotics, adaptogens, or nootropics. These product-line expansions are growing in popularity as they offer convenience and a fast and easy route to a cognitive boost or stress-ameliorating effect.

Probiotic drinks can be categorized into a number of groupings, which include (but are not limited to): alcohol/fermented, dairy, nondairy, high pressure-processed (HPP) juices, vegan, and sport (protein). Within these groups, taste and convenience remain the top consumer priority, but the secondary claims also have enough consumer importance to warrant unique probiotic drink subcategories.

20.6 “Clean label” and “absence of”

Consumers will often speak of a desire for a product with a *clean label*, but the idea of a *clean label* has no regulatory definition for a marketer or a manufacturer. Consumers generally think of a *clean label* product as having ingredients that are recognizable, generally considered to be wholesome in nature, and contain as few ingredients as possible. It involves moving away from highly processed ingredients and moving towards ingredients from natural sources.

Marketers have embraced the *clean label* product positioning by focusing on the “absence of” ingredients. Depending on the consumer group’s specific concerns, common examples of “absence of” communications include the absence of added sugar, lactose, gluten, genetically modified organisms (GMO), etc. The rise in plant-based probiotic beverages ties in with the “cleaner living” movement as plant-based products continue to move into the realm of mainstream consumer products. Consumers look to manufacturers expecting transparency of ingredients as well as ingredient education where appropriate. Consumers expect transparency of ingredient information on both the product website as well as on the product packaging, with an understanding that consumers will use this information to make their purchase decisions.

“Better-for-you” renditions of familiar products are also a growing category (e.g., probiotic sodas and waters). These beverages have a marketing focus not on the “absence of” things such as sugars or fats, but rather on the benefits of additions such as live probiotics. As the consumer is already familiar with the traditional product, this has the potential to be an opportunity for consumer upsell in terms of appeal.

20.7 Benefit stacking and health halos in new product development

Benefit stacking for probiotic beverages refers to the marketing practice of expanding a product’s promoted features by adding other desirable features to the probiotic bacteria in the drink. This can expand the product’s

appeal, and the additions can take many forms, including prebiotics, post-biotics, and psychobiotics.

While a single product may offer multiple benefits to the consumer, often one benefit is perceived as having more importance than the others. A “health halo” is the term for a single health benefit that causes a consumer to have a favorable impression of the overall product. The presence of a “health halo” distinguishes a product from its competitors and may result in the consumer perceiving the product as being virtuous in all respects.

The Irish food company *Kerry* approaches new product development marketing as a three-part process using something familiar to the customer and combining it with “benefit stacking” and a “health halo.” New products developed by Kerry have the following: (1) the welcome mat (an ingredient familiar to the consumer such as strawberry), (2) the “health halo” (a trending ingredient associated with benefits to the immune system such as ginger) and (3) “the hero” (a scientifically proven ingredient supporting immunity or gut health, such as a live probiotic bacteria) (Kerry, 2020). The inclusion of the scientifically proven ingredient, or as Kerry calls it the “hero,” also addresses the consumers’ desire for a transparent and trustworthy ingredient that offers benefits and convenience.

20.8 New technologies

Globally, over 2.25 billion cups of coffee and over 3 billion cups of tea are consumed daily, creating a robust hot beverage market filled with product variations and where new innovative products are brought to market every year. Coffee and tea infused with probiotics offer a benefit-driven familiar product that is easy for consumers to incorporate into their daily routines. For example, US consumers, who currently average three cups of coffee per day can substitute a current coffee product for a probiotic-enhanced coffee without substantially impacting their daily habits while easily incorporating additional health benefits into their lives. The technology that has allowed for the production of probiotic hot drinks is the use of spore-forming strains of probiotic bacteria. The spores are more resistant to the extremes of heat, cold, pH, and pressure than vegetative cells. Even in the highly acidic and high-temperature environment of coffee or tea, these hardier bacteria now offer the opportunity for live probiotics to find their way into the consumer’s gut.

The addition of a probiotic to a hot drink can be introduced at various stages in the beverage making process. The US company *JÛS by Julie* launched a probiotic cold brew coffee product, and US *Tipton Mills* launched a probiotic instant coffee. Both incorporate a probiotic branded *Bacillus coagulans* strain (Ganeden BC30) from Ganeden Biotech (Cleveland).

Offering a probiotic beverage in a nontraditional format, *Vitacup* created a probiotic-infused coffee k-cup pod. These pods quickly produce a probiotic hot coffee product using the already popular standard coffee pod equipment. Incorporated into the coffee pods are probiotic strains with spores that can survive the high brewing temperature. The marketing material claims that there are 1 billion colony-forming units (CFUs) of heat-stable probiotic bacteria present in each pod (heat-resistant *Bacillus coagulans*), and the pods also include aloe vera and B vitamins (an example of benefit stacking).

Vitacup also markets probiotic tea bags with aloe vera and B vitamins. There is a wide variety of probiotic teas on the marketplace, especially herbal and organic options, using heat-tolerant spores with probiotic strains. It is easy to benefit stack tea by incorporating high nutrient ingredients, such as vitamin C and ginger, further adding to their consumer appeal.

Targeting the consumer's desire for convenience, in 2020, Nestlé embarked on a group of innovative drinks called "*nesQino*," drink sachets that can be used with Q-cup machines to quickly make hot or cold drinks. The base sachets can be dairy milk, cereals, or plant-based materials along with sachets that contain probiotics. Consumers choose one "superfood sachet" and "one base sachet" to make a drink, allowing for a wide range of customization (21 options) and a drink ready in under 2 minutes. Initially launched in China, *nesQino* was aimed at Millennials and Gen-Z consumers, known for their high interest in personalized nutrition products. The product claims on the packaging include highlighting the absence of additives, preservatives, artificial colors, and artificial flavors. Further personalization of the beverages is supported through a *nesQino* smartphone app for the Q-cup machine, which allows for the personalization of drink temperature, recipe combinations, and nutritional information.

AliveBiome, a UK start-up, launched a probiotic water drink with an innovative cap, which contains a blend of probiotics, vitamins, and minerals in an airtight container to maintain viability. With a twist of the cap, the seal breaks, the probiotics are released into the water, and the drink is ready for consumption. As the probiotic market continues to expand, technological innovations will continue to create new delivery methods to add probiotics into previously microbe unfriendly environments.

20.9 Developing market opportunities—The young, the old, and the athlete

While there is an emphasis on the role that probiotic beverages can play in helping consumers age well, they also appeal to a younger demographic focused on preventative care at an earlier life stage. There is a lack

of probiotic beverages designed specifically for the senior consumers despite the growing geriatric population.

Child-focused probiotic beverages are also an area of opportunity for future market growth. There appears to be a gap in functional beverages that target this young group, but that is slowly starting to change. The Californian company *Once upon a Farm* is marketing dairy-free smoothies designed for babies, toddlers, and young children. The refrigerated smoothie is made with organic fruits and vegetables, cold-pressed, and with probiotics added for gut and immune health. The packaging for this group is in bisphenol A (BPA)-free and recyclable pouches, but also with some smoothies offered in child-friendly bottles for older children.

The sports drink market is well-developed and continues to expand in its product offerings. Sports nutrition has often focused on antioxidants and energy claims in their marketing material. However, probiotics as a part of a sports nutrition drink is an area of new product innovation, usually through the combination of probiotics with protein drinks for workout recovery. Probiotics in protein drinks can increase the absorption of critical nutrients, such as amino acids from proteins, decrease the incidence of upper respiratory infections, and improve recovery from muscle-damaging exercise; all sought after health benefits for the sports drink consumer (Jäger et al., 2019; Jäger, Mohr, & Pugh, 2020).

20.10 The market message in 2020

Successful marketing plans adjust to the needs of the times to stay relevant to the consumers. Social media and social media influencers have changed how probiotic beverages are being marketed, especially in the time of COVID-19.

Social media—Marketing to Millennials and Gen Z—One of the most effective ways to reach Millennials when considering marketing options is social media. Millennials are a large consumer target market, with strong purchasing power. With Millennials being the largest purchasers of probiotics, this demographic sector is a key market focus.

Globally, over 4.5 billion people use the internet, and active social media users number over 3.8 billion. In 2020, Instagram is one of the most popular social media platforms with over 1 billion monthly active users. Millennials reinforce new trends on their social media platforms where they like to document their healthy lifestyle. They like third party recommendations, dislike traditional advertising, and value brand authenticity. As they check their smartphones on an average over 43 times a day, social media marketing is a key pathway to reach Millennials through advertising, peer reviews, and social media influencer recommendations (Social Toaster, 2020). Gen Z (52%) and Millennials (62%) often turn to social

media health influencers when looking for health information and new wellness trends, such as probiotic beverages ([Specialty Enzymes and Probiotics, 2020](#)).

Millennials have shown a high interest in purchasing probiotic beverages due to the tie in with their social media accounts and other internet platform links. Influencer marketing (ranging from celebrities to health specialists) is an area that continues to grow. Influencers are shaping trends, and online health advice and social media generate awareness in this consumer group.

Storytelling—One of the most effective and popular marketing techniques is selling with “storytelling,” and 56% of global consumers say the stories around a brand influence their purchase decisions ([Innova, 2020](#)). “Storytelling” is a way to connect to the consumer, build trust in a product, and create top of mind awareness. A well-crafted story can teach the consumer about the product’s origin, history, and ingredient provenance, and it can be tied into a company’s work around sustainability and corporate social responsibility.

A successful use of storytelling and capturing current trends is illustrated by *Skyr*, a company that produces traditional Icelandic dairy products. With their drinkable yogurt-like smoothies, they communicate an exciting story about Viking history and about their production process. They teach the consumer how the beverage is traditionally made in Iceland using a low-temperature fermentation, live and active probiotics, and they connect the beverage to the unique local history associated with their microbial cultures. Consumers are educated about how the product is low-fat as it is made from skim milk as well as the fact that it has more protein and less sugar than similar traditional products. Nordic fruits such as lingonberry and bilberry are used, enabling the marketers to advertise the product as low-lactose, gluten-free, and free of artificial ingredients such as sweeteners, vegan friendly, and non-GMO. Although the product sold in the United States is not produced in Iceland, there is transparency about this fact on the US website. This product is also an excellent example of benefit stacking and “absence of” and “better-for-you” claims. It contains “halo” ingredients, as well as adventuresome and health trending fruits (lingonberry and bilberry), and of course, probiotic bacteria with a special story, and the presence of yeast. This high protein source of fermented dairy makes it appealing to the sports consumer segment as well. One can see how this product hits many of the key touchstones identified as important to consumers.

Convenient shots—Convenience is a key priority to consumers. Many prefer not to take supplements in the form of pills or powders but still seek convenient ways to get the benefit of live probiotic organisms into their daily diet. The class of probiotic drinks called “shots” addresses this consumer need. A popular example is Activia’s probiotic yogurt drink,

marketed as “*Activia Shots*,” which emphasizes that it has “the least sugar on the market” and that the probiotic organisms contribute to healthy gut flora. Under the Actimel brand, there are 100% dairy-free *Actimel Shots* containing roasted almonds, oats, and two probiotic live cultures (incl. *Lactobacillus casei*) along with vitamins D and B6. The shots are advertised as low in sugar, no additives, and suitable for vegans.

An example of both sustainability and social responsibility can be seen in the actions of the Minneapolis-based company “*So Good So You*.” The company uses botanical ingredients for their organic, plant-based, probiotic, cold-pressed juice shots—marketed as vegan and non-GMO, with names such as “immunity,” “longevity,” and “sleep,” and with key ingredients of ginger, turmeric, and California poppy, respectively. What makes this company stand out from competitive companies with similar products is how much their communications focus on the importance of sustainability as shown with their drink shots. They were the first to use a biodegradable polyethylene terephthalate (PET) product for their packaging. During the time of COVID-19, they have been actively donating care packages containing their immune-boosting juice shots to the local medical workers and others in hard-hit areas. In addition, they use Instagram as a way for consumers to nominate frontline workers to receive care packages of probiotic shot drinks. In a recent interview, the company cofounders said that it was about more than just helping the frontline workers stay healthy, that it was about making certain they felt supported and remembered.

Waters and sodas—In the development of new probiotic beverages, it is important to consider the consumer’s desire for a multisensory experience that includes not only taste, appearance, and aroma, but also mouthfeel and even sound.

Sparkling waters and soda pops are now available as probiotic beverages. For mouthfeel, seltzer, and sparkling waters tingle on the taste buds and offer the sound of small bubbles popping, adding to the drinking experience. An example of a probiotic soda that falls into the “better-for-you” marketing category is *Culture Pop*. Launched in the summer of 2020, with its brightly decorated aluminum can, it has the look of regular soda pop, with a tag line of “*it’s a soda that is actually good for you*.” On the can, it calls itself “*a fizzy and gutzy probiotic soda*.” It targets many current consumer desires such as: live probiotic organisms, low in calories (40 calories), gluten-free, vegan, plant-based, non-GMO, and offers a mix of fruit flavors. “Better-for-you” renditions of familiar products that mimic iconic sodas include the brand *Live Soda*, which offers typical soda pop flavors such as cola and root beer and promotes the products as zero sugar by using monk fruit as the sweetener. This particular drink contains live probiotics, and it uses the familiarity of well-loved flavors combined with a new added benefit.

Prebiotic sodas—A “better-for-you” US prebiotic soda is *Poppi*, which has a loyal following of Generation X and Millennial consumers after it was made famous on the television (TV) show “Shark Tank.” Currently, on track to become the show’s first billion-dollar company, *Poppi* is marketed as a prebiotic soda. It is a fruit-juice product combined with apple cider vinegar. Apple cider vinegar is very popular in the “alternative” and “natural health” community, with the prebiotic factor ascribed to the fermented apples and pectin. The resulting product is a very drinkable beverage with an array of famous social media influencers touting its tastes and benefits on Instagram.

Another example of a prebiotic beverage is *Clue* prebiotic water, where the prebiotic is not apple cider vinegar but rather an added fructooligosaccharide. Most prebiotics included in beverages are oligosaccharides and *Clue* prebiotic water contains 4g of fructooligosaccharides (also called FOS) in each 16oz bottle. Fructooligosaccharides are believed to aid in digestive functions, immune health, calcium absorption, and are a good source of fiber that is then available as food for the beneficial bacteria already present in the gut microbiome, thus, stimulating an increase in these beneficial bacteria.

Probiotic juice drinks—Popular new products in this area are the high pressure-processed (HPP) juice drinks (i.e., the juice has been cold pasteurized). The process kills 99.9% of the microorganisms present. It is a nonthermal process that helps the product retain a fresh-squeezed taste while giving it a longer shelf life than one would get with a cold-pressed juice. Certain strains of sporulated commercially available probiotic organisms (such as *Bacillus coagulans* from [GanedenBC30](#)) can survive high pressure while problem organisms that cause spoilage, such as molds, are inactivated. The HPP processing of fruit and vegetable juices for probiotic drinks has gained additional momentum during the COVID-19 pandemic. Consumers are looking for products to boost their immune system, support a clean eating lifestyle, and that have a longer shelf life, which means fewer trips to the grocery store.

In 2014, *Garden of Flavor* was one of the first probiotic juices on the US market using HPP technology and the GanedenBC30 probiotic strain. Their first three flavors at that time were marketed as Green Harmony, Appleade, and Turmeric Tonic. Their product line has expanded, with a profusion of organic ingredients. As an example, their cold-pressed energy wheatgrass pineapple juice is described as containing all organic ingredients (guayusa, pineapple juice, wheatgrass juice, kale juice, spinach juice, romaine juice, lemon juice, and mint-leaf juice) and water and a probiotic organism content of *Bacillus coagulans* GBI-30 at a level of 500 million per serving.

Advertising and social media—The power of social media to connect with key target consumers should not be underestimated. Of the paid ads in Q4 2019, 96.1% of ads were seen on mobile devices and 3.9% on

desktop access. Facebook received 58% of the relative ad spend in Q1 of 2019, followed by Instagram feed and Instagram stories, which combined received 28.4% of relative ad spend. For brands mentioned by influencers, data shows that in Q4 2019, there was considerable growth in influencer marketing (using #AD or local language version). In the last quarter of 2019, Instagram's total audience surpassed Facebook with the higher engagement of posts on Instagram. Women aged 25–34 were the largest group engaging with brands on Facebook in terms of interacting with brand pages.

Instagram stories and tap backs—Instagram stories are an important format for brand communications. The tap back rate is the number of times a viewer taps on the left side of a screen to rewatch a previous story. Socialbakers reports that the industries that got the most viewers to tap back to rewatch their Instagram stories were e-Commerce and beverages (both with a median rate of 2.72%), followed by alcohol (2.66%) (SocialBakers, 2020). Storytelling, combined with social media marketing, when performed well can be so engaging that consumers choose to rewatch the advertising more than once.

20.11 Concluding thoughts

With COVID-19, there has never been a better time for brands to promote immune-supporting drinks, especially in the underdeveloped senior market. COVID-19 immunity support is on the consumer's mind. While the effects of COVID-19 in the coming year on consumer preferences and purchases are yet to be determined, early indications are that there will be even more interest in well-produced and well-marketed probiotic beverages if the consumer is confident that their consumption will lead to a tasty and convenient way to reach better health outcomes in daily life.

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